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Colonialism’s Civilising Mission

In the background unnoticed by many, the British government was continuing with its civilising mission all along. It is how the imperial masters understood its colonized peoples. The trial and execution of Bhagat Singh in 1931 is an example of legal historiography of colonial violence which arises from this so-called civilising mission. Kim Wagner, a scholar of the history of colonial India and the British Empire, has recently described how ‘a growing body of scholarship has explored the role of colonial violence, both epistemic and physical, as an intrinsic aspect of British and European imperialism’. However, Wagner maintains, ‘[t]he insights provided by such studies have yet to make much of an inroad in conventional historiography of the Empire.’ His work thus sets out to examine ‘the violence at the heart of British colonial counterinsurgency during the high-point of Empire’[1] instead of merely ‘settler violence’ on which much has been written. Yet if this shortcoming is true of ‘conventional historiography’, it is doubly true of the ‘legal historiography’ of the British Empire in India. The Lahore Conspiracy Case and the trial of Bhagat Singh are cases in point. In fact, the backdrop to Wagner’s valuable study is precisely that ‘[w]ithin the last few years the subject of colonial violence has come to the fore in debates on the legacies of the British Empire, with a range of lawsuits and calls for formal apologies and reparation . . .’.[2] The purpose of this discussion is to demonstrate that the execution of Bhagat Singh falls squarely within this milieu. Indeed, there can scarcely be a more deserving case.

Thus, Wagner has explained how, ‘British knowledge and understanding of the people they fought throughout the Empire was invariably shaped by